all electoral records with a sixth consecutive term for the BJD and himself. Elections to the state's 147 legislative assembly seats are being held simultaneously with that for its 21 Lok Sabha seats. If Naveen wins and becomes chief minister again, he will be in pole position to overtake Pawan Chamling's record as the longest-serving chief minister in the country's legislative history. Chamling was Sikkim CM for 24 years and 165 days. On June 4, when the results will be announced, Naveen would have completed 24 years and 91 days, short by a mere 74 days to claim the top honours. But should he fail to secure a majority in the state polls, he will be history as, at age 77, this will probably be the last election he will contest.

More than a show of force, these rallies are a show of face for Naveen. Especially after leaders of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), his main rival in the state, have spread vile rumours about him being seriously ill, suffering from dementia perhaps and becoming a puppet in the hands of a clique of Tamil-speaking IAS officers who are actually running the show. Much of that criticism is directed at V. Karthikeya Pandian, his former private secretary, who resigned from the IAS in October 2023 and was appointed chairman of the state's powerful 5T programme, his cabinet minister status giving him the authority to oversee all the key state government departments. Pandian, who subsequently joined the BJD and is now the party's star campaigner, is accused of being de facto chief minister and projected to be Naveen's successor. Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan, contesting from the Sambalpur Lok Sabha constituency and a potential CM candidate, minced no words when he asked, "Where is Naveen Patnaik? He is seen only in videos and is absent in the field. Neither the ministers nor the secretaries can meet him. There is simmering resentment against him in his party as he is in the grip of a cartel."

BJP'S GAME PLAN

The BJP has also made restoring Odia "*asmita*" (pride) its primary election plank and pledged to stop "outsiders" like Pandian, who is of Tamil origin, from ruling the state. Having made deep inroads into the state, the party has overtaken the Congress as the principal challenger to the BJD. In the 2019 Lok Sabha election, the BJP increased its 2014 tally of one seat to eight, securing 38.4 per cent of the votes, while the BJD won 12 seats and netted 42.8 per cent of the votes. That streak did not extend to the assembly polls, though, where Naveen won with a landslide, as he did in 2014. The

TO NET MORE LS SEATS AND ALSO UNSEAT NAVEEN IN THE ASSEMBLY POLLS, THE BJP IS BANKING ON MODI'S POPULARITY RATHER THAN ON LOCAL LEADERS TO WIN BIG

BJD won 112 of the 147 seats in the 2019 assembly polls, 38 more than the 74 seats it needed for a simple majority. It also managed to increase its vote share by 1.3 percentage points to 44.7 per cent, but saw a five-seat erosion on its 2014 tally. The BJP vote share in the 2019 assembly election, on the other hand, grew by 14.5 percentage points to 32.5 per cent; the party also secured 23 seats, 13 more than in 2014, but still woefully short of the number it needs in order to bridge the wide chasm and fell the BJD.

In the current round of elections, the BJP is hoping not only to win more Lok Sabha seats in the state but also to decimate the BJD in the assembly polls and oust Naveen. In that endeavour, there is no insult the BJP is not hurling at the Odisha CM. Sambit Patra, the BJP candidate from Puri, after organising a successful roadshow for Prime Minister Narendra Modi in the temple town, mocked Naveen while talking to INDIA TODAY, "Naveen Patnaik has become a demi-god, a deity who does not blink, does not speak and does not sleep. He watches stonily as *pandas* (pandits) like Pandian perform the rituals of running the state. By speaking less, he retains his mystique, and the people's curses are directed towards the pandits rather than against him for non-performance. But we will ensure that it is game over for Naveen."



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